

HOW-TO GUIDES

23 Questions Every Heavy AI User Should Ask

A checklist for the rest of us



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APR 13, 2026

THE ALGORITHMIC BRIDGE

by Alberto Romero



Hey there, I'm Alberto! 🙌

Each week, I publish long-form AI analysis covering culture, philosophy, and business The Algorithmic Bridge. Paid subscribers also get Monday how-to guides and Friday news commentary. I publish occasional extra articles. If you'd like to become a paid subscriber, here's a button for that:

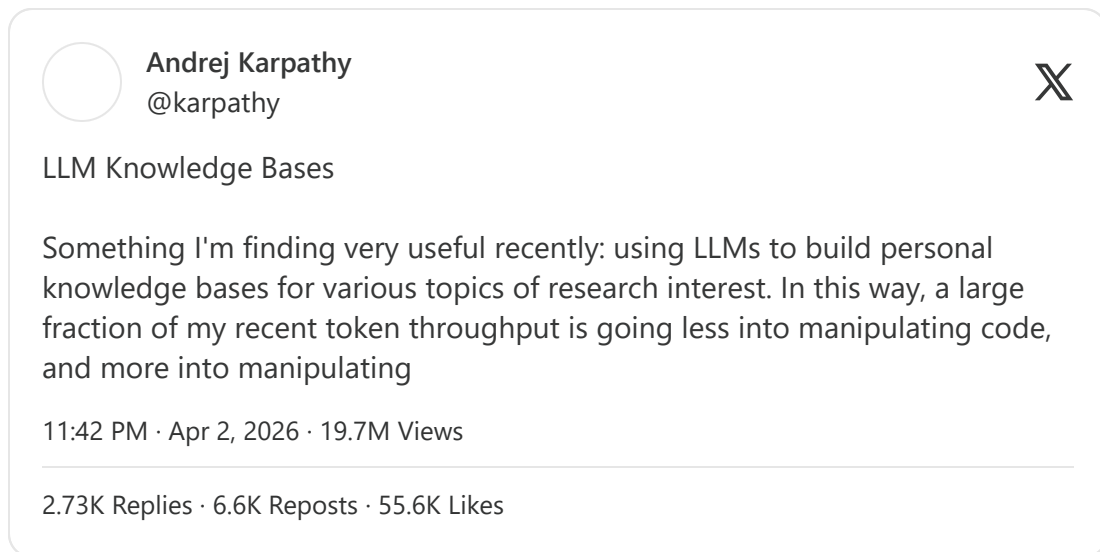
Everyone's using AI now. At the same time, everyone is starting to notice a bunch of issues and caveats that are emerging with the growing use of this technology. And yet far as I know, nobody has made a periodic self-check for AI users.

There are vendor evaluation questionnaires (for companies buying AI), prompting guides (for people learning the basics), and tool comparison lists (for people choosing between products). But there's nothing for the person who uses AI every day and wants to make sure they're not drifting. Thinking about "how you use a tool" is less exciting than using the tool. But it might matter more.

This is my first attempt at that (this is for myself, but it might be of use to you).



I've been using AI tools every day for over five years now. I research with AI, brainstorm with it, edit with it, and build personal software tools with it. I'm not yet the multi-agent stage, but it will eventually happen. My current project is akin to [Karpathy's wiki/knowledge base](#), but for the entire archive of writing, reading, and interesting stuff that I've been capturing and classifying for years, rather than research.



At this point, my workflow is more AI than not-AI. I'm faster than I've ever been and work more than I've ever worked (that's why I wrote "[The Most Important Skill in AI Right Now: How to Know When to Stop](#)" and "[How to Deal With Infinite Options](#)").

Yesterday—because I'm too methodical or hedge too much—I sat down to write something without relying on AI assistance from beginning to end—research, editing grammar, etc.—just to see how it felt, and realized a tinge of vertigo. Not having an enabled "safety net" made me feel weirdly vulnerable (in case you don't know, English is not my first language, and so I make typos, confuse words, and misuse expressions etc., at a higher rate than normal).

My work was slower and less comfortable, and I kept reaching for a Claude tab. Imagine you had to work for a day without the internet, it'd be supremely restricting right? But AI is so new! How is this happening to me already?

My answer is that, for most heavy users using AI for serious work, this shift is going to happen for AI much faster than it did for the internet or the phone. These tools rewired speed, so here we are, with a superpower in our hands, doing more than ever, faster than ever, always monitoring the next release or announcement.

And yet.

Have you taken the time to step back for a second and ask whether you're actually getting better at what you do or just getting faster? Whether you're getting smarter or dumber? Whether your work is better or just more abundant?

I haven't.

And I have noticed, after writing those other posts I mentioned above, that it's not the people who use AI the most who will reach further, but those who start to ask the right questions about the best practices. Those who dedicate 5% of their time to reflect.

This is, it turns out, an old problem with an old solution: the checklist.

To convince you, I've compiled four cases in chronological order. You can jump this section if you are already convinced, but I found these four guys' approaches to be genuinely interesting despite centuries between them and us (except the last one). They are the predecessors to our current work methodology.

1. Lucius Annaeus Seneca (4 BC - AD 65)
2. Ignatius of Loyola (1491 - 1556)
3. Benjamin Franklin (1706 - 1790)

4. Atul Gawande (1965 -)

Seneca's most famous line is "It is not that we have a short time to live, but that we waste a lot of it." He did not suffer from the laziness that afflicts most of us.

He was one of the sharpest minds in Rome—second in charge to Nero while he was boy—and he had a nightly practice where he reviewed his entire day. "What did I see? What did I do? What could I have done better?" He describes it in *De Ira* (on anger), and he makes it sound remarkably undramatic: he doesn't frame it as self-punishment or spiritual discipline or personal development but as standard maintenance.

He already knew how to live well (although for what we know from his writings on happiness, he could've done a better job). The review was about making sure he was doing it. Seneca understood something that I think applies directly to us: knowing what to do and *actually doing it* are different problems.

Fifteen centuries later, Ignatius of Loyola—a Spaniard, which I appreciate—took this idea and turned it into a system: *The Examen*. Five steps and five minutes. Twice a day.

It was designed for Jesuits, the most committed, most disciplined practitioners in the Catholic world, so he tailored it, naturally, for religious stuff. But it's a useful reference because it was *for experts*. (You may not think of yourself as such, but consider what 99% of the population knows about using AI and then think again.)

Loyola understood that the review becomes more valuable the more competent you already are—not the other way around—because 1) complacency hides in competence and 2) an incompetent person could not even parse it! A beginner may not know what they don't know, but an expert forgets how much they know.

Then Ben Franklin—probably the one that's most familiar to you—took the whole thing out of the spiritual domain—this is during the 18th-century Enlightenment—and made it practical with his 13 virtues. He tracked one per week, cycled through all 13 every quarter, and kept a chart (he would have loved [Claude Excel](#)).

Franklin's system made explicit what Seneca and Loyola left implicit: any single day's answers are meaningless; "I failed at Temperance today, so what?" The insight is *in the pattern across months*. He also said, and I love this, that he never achieved the perfection the system aimed at, but that *the practice of checking* made him better than he would have been without it.

Finally, Atul Gawande—the only one here that's still alive—proved all of this empirically in 2009.

He wrote [*The Checklist Manifesto*](#) after studying a case at Johns Hopkins: a team created a five-step checklist for inserting central line catheters. When they made it mandatory to run the checklist every time for ICU doctors—who knew it by heart—the infection rate dropped from 11% to zero!

Essentially, they stopped skipping steps they had been skipping solely motivated by the *tricky disability of expertise*. Gawande's key finding is that the doctors who resist the checklist the most were the most senior ones. It felt beneath them. And yet, they were the ones who benefited the most. That's us, you and me, pioneers in the use of AI, paving the way for those who come after, failing to notice our flaws.

Summing up: Seneca introduced the principle of the checklist, Loyola focused it on experts, Franklin introduced consistency, and Gawande proved it empirically.



This maps directly onto how we're using AI.

And I'm going to show you how.

As I see it, we are in the Seneca stage, trying to develop some principles and good practices as we go. This is good, but also primitive and heuristic-based.

Nobody (that I'm aware of) does a monthly AI retrospective.

Or checks whether their dependency has deepened, their skills have atrophied, their taste has drifted toward the model's defaults, or whether they're producing more but thinking less. We just keep going. There are papers and surveys and studies every now and then that talk about this ([MIT](#), [Wharton](#), etc.), and the [occasional blog post](#), but you want to wait for that? I don't think so.

This will eventually be an imperative task: Every field where the stakes are high enough eventually builds some kind of periodic review into the practice. Surgery, aviation, spiritual life, personal development, and now AI. This technology is already reshaping how millions of people work, and it has zero review culture around it.

I think we need a checklist.

So I made one.

It's 23 questions.

This is a prototype, a personal checklist I've done for myself, to keep me on track. The broad idea is to make the user reflect on the use of AI and improve it from the very act of asking these questions (also from the answer, of course). These questions will evolve, change, and I will add new ones, but it's a starting point that I think can be useful for you as well.

Steal it and run it once a month. Even a quick skim is better than nothing!

Eventually, you will want to iterate on these questions as you see fit. This is not intended to be a rigid, fixed, one-fits-all checklist, but the exact opposite: ideally, you will have a checklist so tailored for your work and use cases that, by the time it is truly useful to you, none of my questions will remain.

Take this post as my attempt to get you going!



Your work

1. Did you edit or rework every output before shipping it?
2. Did you catch the AI getting something wrong this month?
3. Was your vibe-coding worth the time you saved quality-wise?
4. If you timed your AI-assisted tasks end-to-end, did you save time?
5. Are you better at your job than you were a month ago?

Your skills

6. Did you do at least one task without AI this month that you normally use AI for
7. Could you still do your most important task at the same quality without AI?
8. Did you sit alone with a difficult problem before reaching for AI?
9. Did you develop an original idea this month that AI inspired?
10. Can you tell when AI output is wrong in your domain?

Your growth

11. Did you make something you could not have made without AI?
12. Did you hold back from producing something despite it being easy to make?
13. Is your AI-assisted work better than your pre-AI work?
14. Did you learn to do something novel with the help of AI?

Your habits

15. Did you replace AI's default structure with your own at least once?

- 16. Did you tailor your prompts to each tool?
- 17. Have you used at least once everything you built with AI?
- 18. Did you use the right tools for the right tasks?
- 19. Did you double-check an output that confirmed your biases?

Your dependency

- 20. Could you do tomorrow's work without any AI?
- 21. Do you use every AI tool you're currently paying for?
- 22. If the price doubled, could you walk away without panic?
- 23. Could you switch to a competing AI without rebuilding everything?



Here's a PDF with a checklist for your convenience, so you can re-use every month:



AI CHECKLIST

4.45MB · PDF file

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